

Misurata Free Zone

Libya's Premier Gateway for Strategic Investment

Established 2000 | Mediterranean Coast | 2,500+ Hectares

Information provided by the Misurata Free Zone Prepared by the Libyan British Business Council for prospective UK investors and partners

Misurata Free Zone is Libya's first economic free zone, strategically positioned on the Mediterranean coast to serve as a natural gateway between Africa, Europe, and the Middle East.

MFZ owns and operates the largest and busiest commercial port in Libya, ranked among the top 20 globally for port performance (World Bank, 2024). The zone manages over 65% of Libya's container trade and provides a secure, regulated environment for international commerce and industrial development.

Total land capacity spans 2,500+ hectares, divided into Site A (Maritime, Logistics & Investment Gateway) and Site B (Heavy Industrial Development Zone).

Investment Value Proposition

Fast & Simple Setup

One-stop company registration and licensing process with streamlined regulatory compliance. Investors retain full flexibility to recruit local or foreign labour based on operational requirements.

Complete Ownership & Financial Freedom

- 100% foreign ownership permitted
- Zero corporate and personal income tax
- No customs duties on imported materials and equipment
- Unrestricted repatriation of profits and capital

Reliable Infrastructure & Utilities

Direct access to water, power and industrial gas at competitive local rates, plus modern port facilities, integrated logistics hubs, administrative complexes and pre-serviced industrial plots.

Six Priority Investment Projects

MFZ is actively seeking international financing and strategic partnerships across Sites A and B.

Infrastructure Development (Site B)

Objective: Create fully serviced, investment-ready land to enable rapid industrial and logistics development.

Key components: Internal road networks, power generation and distribution, water supply and sewage infrastructure, stormwater drainage, ICT and telecoms infrastructure, land preparation and plot servicing.

Ideal investor profile: Infrastructure developers, utilities providers, EPC contractors.

Free Logistics Zone (Misrata Airport)

Objective: Establish a dedicated platform for fast, efficient cargo handling and multimodal logistics operations.

Key components: Warehousing and distribution facilities, air cargo handling infrastructure, cold storage for pharmaceuticals and food products, logistics and freight forwarding services.

Ideal investor profile: Logistics operators, cold chain specialists, freight forwarders.

Industrial Complexes

Objective: Provide ready-to-operate industrial facilities to reduce investor setup time and capital expenditure.

Key components: Pre-built factories and modular industrial units, heavy and light industrial zones, modern warehouses, maintenance and utilities support services.

Ideal investor profile: Industrial real estate developers, facility managers, manufacturing investors.

Fishing Port

Objective: Develop a fully integrated fisheries value chain leveraging Libya's marine resources.

Key components: Modern berths for fishing vessels, fish landing and handling facilities, processing and packaging units, cold storage and export infrastructure, aquaculture projects, fleet support services.

Ideal investor profile: Fisheries operators, cold chain investors, aquaculture developers.

Shipbuilding & Maintenance Zone

Objective: Establish a regional maritime service hub supporting shipbuilding, repair, and technical workforce development.

Key components: Shipyard expansion, marine engineering and fabrication workshops, spare parts supply and marine logistics facilities, training services for marine engineers and technicians.

Ideal investor profile: Marine engineering firms, shipbuilders, technical training providers.

Business Administration Zone (Phase II)

Objective: Create an advanced professional business environment supporting international corporate presence.

Key components: Additional office units to accommodate growing demand, new supporting amenities outside the current administrative cluster.

Ideal investor profile: Property developers, business services firms, commercial real estate investors.

Strategic Context: The Eni Offshore Gas Discovery

In March 2026, Eni announced two significant offshore gas discoveries (Bahr Essalam South 2 and Bahr Essalam South 3) located approximately 85 kilometres off Libya's western coast. Preliminary estimates indicate reserves exceeding 1 trillion cubic feet (Tcf) of gas in place. The discoveries are situated near existing Bahr Essalam infrastructure, enabling accelerated commercial development through tie-backs to current offshore facilities rather than requiring entirely new platform construction.

What this means for MFZ investors

- Proximity and logistics support: MFZ is the nearest integrated industrial and logistics hub to the western Libyan coast, positioned to serve as a staging area for equipment, materials and workforce mobilisation.
- Infrastructure demand acceleration: rapid offshore development will increase regional demand for power, water treatment, telecoms and transport — directly addressed by MFZ's Site B infrastructure project.
- Supply chain and marine services: the Free Logistics Zone and Shipbuilding & Maintenance Zone are positioned to host fabrication workshops, spare parts distribution, marine support vessels and technical training.
- Economic diversification catalyst reinforces Libya's position as a key Mediterranean energy supplier and creates immediate demand for non-energy industrial and logistical services.

FAQ — Banking & Getting Paid

Which banks operate within Misurata Free Zone?

Jumhouria Bank, Sahara Bank, Libyan Islamic Bank, and Libyan Foreign Bank. MFZ can facilitate introductions to banking representatives for international corporate accounts once a company begins the establishment process.

Can dinar revenue from onshore contracts be transferred internationally?

Companies established within MFZ are required under Law No. 9 of 2000 to maintain both a Libyan dinar account and a foreign currency account. The Free Zone framework does not restrict transfer of capital and profits abroad, though outbound transfers are subject to the company's bank's own documentation and compliance requirements.

Is currency conversion at the official Central Bank of Libya rate, and are there limits?

Conversion and transfers are handled by the company's bank, whether inside or outside MFZ. The applicable rate, approvals, limits and frequency are governed by prevailing banking regulations and the relevant bank's procedures — MFZ does not set exchange rates or approve individual transfers.

Does opening an account require a full MFZ licence and physical presence?

Yes — to benefit from MFZ's legal, financial and investment framework, a company must be duly registered and licensed within the Free Zone, with an approved activity and an allocated office, facility, warehouse or land plot. There is currently no separate lighter registration route confirmed for companies operating principally elsewhere in Libya.

How is dinar revenue from onshore contracts taxed when routed through a zone account?

MFZ-licensed companies benefit from the tax exemptions of the Free Zone framework. Tax treatment of revenue from activity performed outside the zone — including any withholding — depends on the nature and location of that activity under applicable Libyan tax legislation.

Can a Free Zone company hold USD and EUR accounts, and are letters of credit supported?

Yes, subject to the services and procedures of the company's bank. Letters of credit and other trade-finance instruments are provided by the relevant banking institution; MFZ itself does not issue or manage them.

FAQ — Getting Started

Can an international company register from abroad, and how long does it take?

Yes — a company may begin and largely complete registration from abroad via an authorised legal representative. A visit can help with site selection and final arrangements but isn't necessarily required at the initial stage. Once documents are correctly submitted, registration and licensing typically take approximately 7–10 business days, depending on activity type and project complexity.

Branch registration vs. incorporating a Free Zone company — which suits a contractor vs. a long-term investor?

A branch is not normally required to deposit minimum share capital, remains legally connected to its foreign parent, and may only conduct activities within the parent's authorised objectives — often suited to contractors. A newly incorporated Free Zone company has its own legal structure and is subject to minimum-capital requirements — typically better suited to long-term investors.

FAQ — Legal Framework

Are contracts with MFZ governed by Libyan law, and is international arbitration available?

Establishment and operation of companies within MFZ are governed by Law No. 9 of 2000 and the applicable Libyan legal and regulatory framework. Contracts with MFZ are generally governed by Libyan law; international arbitration may be considered for certain strategic or high-value agreements, assessed case-by-case.

What lease terms and renewal rights apply to land within the zone?

Lease terms depend on the type, size, duration and requirements of the proposed investment, and are set out in the relevant investment and lease agreements. Interested companies should contact MFZ directly to discuss project-specific terms.

Do Free Zone protections extend to work performed outside the zone boundary?

MFZ's exemptions, protections and services primarily apply to activity conducted within the zone. Work performed outside the zone may also be subject to ordinary Libyan laws, licensing and tax rules for that location or sector.

FAQ — Projects & Capabilities

Which pipeline projects have confirmed funding and start dates?

Pipeline projects — including the tank farm, oil & gas logistics zone, airport logistics zone, expo centre, hotel and fishing harbour — are at different stages of planning and investment structuring, and are being presented as opportunities for strategic investors, developers, operators and financing partners. British companies are invited to contact MFZ directly to discuss the projects most relevant to their expertise.

Which capabilities is MFZ most seeking internationally, and where do British firms fit?

MFZ is seeking cooperation across EPC contracting, project and programme management, engineering and architectural design, logistics and supply-chain operations, oil & gas support services, specialised equipment and technology, warehouse and cold-chain systems, marine engineering and shipyard services, airport logistics, project financing, and facility operation and maintenance. British firms are particularly well placed in engineering, project management, professional services, maritime operations, energy, technology, compliance, training and infrastructure development.

Companies are welcome to provide a short summary of their area of interest in advance so enquiries can be directed to the relevant department or project team.